

SEX, RELATIONSHIPS, AND COMMUNICATION

RELATIONAL TRANSGRESSIONS



OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- ORI defined:
 - Repeated and unwanted pursuit and invasion of one's sense of physical or symbolic privacy by another person, either stranger or acquaintance, who desires and/or presumes an intimate relationship.

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- Common ORI situations involve unrequited love between:
 - Acquaintances
 - Former relational partners
 - One person wants the relationship to continue.
 - One person wanting a platonic friendship to turn romantic

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- Examples of ORI behaviors:

Common Forms

- repeated calls and/or texts
- repeated social media posts
- repeatedly asking for another chance
- watching from a distance
- making exaggerated claims of affection

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

Severe Forms (commonly known as stalking):

- invading one's home
- damaging property
- causing physical harm

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 1. Lack of mutual agreement regarding the nature or even the existence of a relationship.

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 2. ORI is not associated with a singular event, but is repeated.
 - Pursuit is persistent despite the absence of reciprocity by the other person and despite resistance by the other person.
 - The episodes of unwanted behavior tend to escalate over time, with the seriousness rising and the time between incidents shortening.

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 3. Intrusion can be symbolic and psychological, not just physical.

REASONS FOR ORI

- 1. Relational scripts, particularly those regarding the establishment of romantic/sexual relationships, often idealize and reward persistence.

REASONS FOR ORI



REASONS FOR ORI

- 2. Indirect or ambiguous communication
 - It can be very difficult to tell another person you are not interested in them when they are clearly interested in you.
 - In most instances, we don't want to hurt another person's feelings, so we use indirect or ambiguous communication.
 - Which may be misinterpreted
 - "This person is just playing hard to get."
 - Another cultural script that may encourage ORI

REASONS FOR ORI

- Unrequited love can cause an individual to fixate on a desired person and “justify” (in their own minds) the use of unhealthy pursuit strategies.

ORI

- Flirting behaviors can turn into ORI behaviors if:
 - The flirtee repeatedly indicates he/she is not interested.
 - The flirtee repeatedly does not reciprocate the flirting behaviors.
 - The flirter feels like he/she is having to work very hard to get the other person's attention.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- Theory that explains why ORI behaviors occur.
 - Three parts.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 1. People expend energy to develop or re-initiate relationships to the extent that they perceive a relationship is desirable and attainable.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 2. When a relationship is perceived to be unattainable, people abandon their original goal and seek an alternative.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 3. ORI behaviors are most likely when people continue to believe a relationship is attainable even though it is not.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- People who use ORIs in an attempt to get closer to another person:
 - Mentally link the desired relationship to exaggerated feelings of happiness and exaggerated feeling of self-worth.
 - “I will never be happy unless he/she goes out with me.”
 - “I know I am a good person if he/she goes out with me.”

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- These mental links also produces exaggerated negative feelings toward failing to “win” the other person over.
 - “I am worthless unless he/she goes out with me.”
- These mental links tend to discourage people from stopping their ORI behaviors and tend to mentally reinforce the importance of a relationship with the other person.

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THE INVESTMENT MODEL OF RELATIONSHIP-MAINTAINING BEHAVIOR

- Predicts that *level of commitment* helps to buffer relationships against the effects of transgressions.

THE INVESTMENT MODEL OF RELATIONSHIP-MAINTAINING BEHAVIOR

- Why do some relationships survive transgressions while others do not?
 - According to IMRMB, the answer is commitment.

THE INVESTMENT MODEL OF RELATIONSHIP-MAINTAINING BEHAVIOR

- Level of commitment involves three components:
 - 1. Satisfaction
 - 2. Investments
 - 3. Alternatives

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: SATISFACTION

- Satisfaction is based on:
 - Rewards, costs, outcomes, and comparison levels

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: SATISFACTION

- Outcome: reward-cost ratio
- *Comparison level*: how rewarding or costly you expect your relationship to be *relative to your perceptions* of other relationships.
 - How do you think your relationship compares to other people's relationships?

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: SATISFACTION

- Satisfaction occurs when:
 - rewards outweigh costs
 - the outcome (reward-cost ratio) is as good as or better than the comparison level
 - Satisfaction predicts commitment.

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: INVESTMENT

- *Investments* are unrecoverable inputs that individuals deposit into relationships
 - What are you putting into the relationship?

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: INVESTMENT

- Two types of investments
 - *1. Intrinsic investments:* resources put directly into the relationship (time, effort).
 - Likely intangible.

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: INVESTMENT

- 2. *Extrinsic investments*: resources developed over time as a result of being in the relationship (possessions, social networks)
 - Likely tangible

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: INVESTMENT

- High investment (both types) predicts commitment.
 - Much more to lose if relationship ends.

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: QUALITY OF ALTERNATIVES

- Considering one's relational options.
 - *Would I be better off with someone else?*
 - *Would I be better off single?*

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: QUALITY OF ALTERNATIVES

- Perception of poor alternatives predicts commitment
 - “I can’t do any better.”
 - Also explains why people stay in unsatisfying relationships.
- Perception of good alternatives predict less commitment
 - “There are other fish in the sea.”

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: COMMITMENT

- So, what predicts commitment?

COMPONENTS OF THE MODEL: COMMITMENT

- Commitment is predicted by:
 - High satisfaction
 - High investment
 - Poor quality of alternatives

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- Committed couples are more likely to engage in **pro-relationship behaviors**.

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- Behaviors used intentionally to maintain a relationship.

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- 1. Deciding to Remain
 - Commitment predicts making the choice to not exit a relationship after transgressions have taken place.



PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- 2. Accommodating the Partner
 - Commitment predicts making the choice to resist engaging in negative reciprocity

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- 3. Derogating Alternatives
 - Commitment predicts will actively find fatal faults with other potential partners

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- 4. Being Willing to Make Sacrifices
 - Commitment predicts making choices about one's time, money, career, and living situation with the relationship in mind.

PRO-RELATIONSHIP BEHAVIORS

- 5. Perceiving Relationship Superiority
 - Commitment predicts that couples choose to believe that their relationship is better than others' relationships.

RELATIONAL REDEFINITION

- Instead of reconciling, some former romantic partners redefine their relationships.
 - Examples:
 - spouses become co-parents
 - a romantic relationship is redefined as a friendship

WHEN SPOUSES BECOME CO-PARENTS

- ~12% regard themselves as good friends 5 years after the divorce
- Friendship is more likely if the divorce was non-adversarial
 - Adversarial around children, resources (money, possessions, real estate)

WHEN ROMANTIC PARTNERS BECOME FRIENDS

- Most dating couples do not continue any type of relationship after breaking up.

WHEN ROMANTIC PARTNERS BECOME FRIENDS

- Among those who do remain friends:
 - around 60% showed a pattern of relationship decline over time (with commitment to the friendship declining in the months after the break up)
 - about 21% of ex-couples became better friends over time

WHEN ROMANTIC PARTNERS BECOME FRIENDS

- Former romantic couples are more likely to be successful in transitioning to a friendship if they:
 - engage in reflective talk
 - realize that they can be happy just being friends

WHEN ROMANTIC PARTNERS BECOME FRIENDS

- exchange social support
- communicate forgiveness for actions that occurred when they were a couple

THINKING ABOUT MARRIAGE AND DIVORCE



WHY DO COUPLES GET DIVORCED?

17 YEAR PANEL SURVEY

- Panel survey – data collected from the same people at multiple points in time.
- 17 year panel study
 - Limitation: only heterosexual couples

WHY DO COUPLES GET DIVORCED? 17 YEAR PANEL SURVEY

- 1. Infidelity (21.6% of divorces)
 - Sexual infidelity
 - Emotional infidelity

WHY DO COUPLES GET DIVORCED?

17 YEAR PANEL SURVEY

- 2. Incompatibility (19.2% of divorces)
 - “birds of a feather” vs. “opposites attract.”
 - Beliefs about money, children, sex, religion
 - Conflict

WHY DO COUPLES GET DIVORCED?

17 YEAR PANEL SURVEY

- 3. Alcohol or drug abuse (10.6% of divorces)
 - Violence
 - Legal problems